

THE LIFE OF ISAAC J. SPARKS

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by
Leo M. ^{Harloe} Harloe

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This thesis, written by

LEO M. HARLOE

*under the guidance of his Faculty Committee,
and approved by all its members, has been
presented to and accepted by the Council on
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ment of the requirements for the degree of*

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Ed. Bogardus

Dean

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Faculty Committee

Chairman

J. M. Weersing

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FOREWORD

The reason men have always followed the setting sun, moving, for the most part, always in a westerly direction as if they are searching for the gold that the sun's rays so closely resemble, is hard to explain. Historians and sociologists have tried to explain this phenomena in volumes too numerous to mention. Frederick Jackson Turner, in his monumental thesis, "The Frontier in American History," has left his imprint permanently on American history in explaining this movement.

Until the frontier was definitely depleted and the ocean reached, the United States could be called an agrarian civilization. This type of civilization affected the American way of life as well as making this country the mecca for the oppressed and downtrodden from other parts of the world. They came here with their meager possessions and a light shining in their eyes to be absorbed into an ever-changing culture.

The area covered in this study goes from one ocean boundary of the United States to the other, and it extends into the Pacific Ocean a total of fifty miles. It is related to American history with the first settlement along the Atlantic coast. From that frontier settlement it then moved in a westerly direction over and around seemingly insurmountable obstacles.

To follow the wanderings of one man across the

uninhabited areas of the United States is almost impossible. To add to the difficulties, he entered what was then part of a foreign country. He traveled across more than two thousand miles of this area, and he never returned, as many of the earlier wanderers were prone to do from time to time. Those who returned left letters and other accounts in the headquarters of the fur traders, mainly St. Louis. These accounts are highly prized by the research worker; in some cases such accounts are very valuable in tracing our early history. As members of migrating parties were inclined to keep diaries and accounts, we have a much clearer picture of these later groups.

Isaac J. Sparks belonged to the earliest of those groups known as the independent fur traders and trappers. He traveled, trapped, and lived with a group of men whose exploits and daring have become a legend in the history of the west. To enumerate a few of the men with whom he associated in his wanderings will make the rest of this paper more readable. Jedediah Smith was one of his co-workers. Sparks was present when Smith met his death at the hands of hostile Indians. Kit Carson and Moses Carson were associated with Sparks in the fur trade. Ewing Young was Sparks' chief on one of his major trapping expeditions into the Colorado region. His California associates will be only enumerated; they were: J. J. Warner, owner of Warner's Ranch, a stopping

place for early settlers coming into California; Isaac Williams, fur trapper and trader, who settled near the present site of Los Angeles with his Indian wife; Captain Williams G. Dana, of Santa Barbara, the uncle of Richard Henry Dana of "Two Years Before the Mast" fame, and a prominent early Californian; George Nidever, of Santa Barbara, fur trapper, owner of the Santa Barbara Channel Islands, and an early California pioneer; Benjamin Foxen, of Los Alamos, associated with Fremont in his capture of Santa Barbara; John M. Price, pioneer Englishman, who settled in California and became part of this new country. These are only a few; but from the names mentioned, the reader can draw some conclusions of what is to come in more detailed form in the paper.

As the early immigrants into California, in nearly all instances, married into the Spanish families, their descendants show the racial mixture. This was not true of Sparks. Although he married a woman who had been born in California and who had a Spanish name, no Spanish blood ran in her veins. This episode constitutes a romantic chapter which will be dealt with in chronological order.

Unlike most of the early settlers, Sparks did not give up his citizenship to become a Mexican subject, and for the first thirteen years of his life in California, he was a fugitive from justice; for he had escaped from the jail in the Pueblo of Los Angeles, and he never returned to face the

charges of being a spy, which had been brought against him.

He also obtained land grants later, to the chagrin of the American courts, who could not understand how an American, who was not married to a Spanish woman and who was a citizen of the United States, could obtain two large land grants and other major holdings from the Mexican government. This caused a great deal of trouble, and his claims were not recognized until after his death.

The religion of all the people in the Spanish colonies at this time was Roman Catholic, and no other religion was allowed to exist; but the facts indicate that Sparks could have been a much better church member. Although his entire family became Roman Catholic and some of them had the honor of being buried within the Santa Barbara Mission, Sparks' remains lie in a cemetery of all faiths outside of Santa Barbara.

In this study the author will endeavor to treat each detail of Isaac Sparks' life to the extent of the available material.

CHAPTER IV

REMOVAL OF THE INDIANS FROM SAN NICOLAS ISLAND

In California the islands off the coast of Santa Barbara are one of the area's most interesting phenomena. They have repeatedly figured in the exploration and conquest of California as they are one of the first stopping places for ships returning from the Pacific Islands. When the sailors who were dying from scurvy and suffering the indescribable agonies which accompany this disease, the curse of earlier mariners, sighted these islands, prayers of thanksgiving were offered to the Virgin Mary.

These islands were of particular importance to the early trappers. During the summer months the sea otter migrated south, and these islands were breeding grounds for them. The otter skins were extremely valuable. Even the great Russian-American Company sent from the north trappers to obtain these skins. As Isaac Sparks and George Nidever were associated in the business of fur trapping, they had something more than a casual interest in these islands.

To clarify the difficulties and hardships involved in the later removal of the Indians from San Nicolas Island, a description of the island and its people is appropriate.

About eighty miles south of Ventura is a wind-swept island which has the appearance of being gently lifted from

the depths of the ocean. The island's altitude is about 800 feet above sea level. It is surrounded by comparatively low banks; there is a gradual acclivity which terminates in abrupt escarpments. The surface of the island is relatively level.¹ This island has a mean length of about nine miles and an average width of about four miles. The longer axis is nearly east and west.

From the geological viewpoint, the island is of recent origin. The fossils, which are numerous in some places, are of quaternary period except some found in the southeastern portion of the island; these latter may probably be classified as Pliocene.

At the time of the removal of the Indians, the island was treeless.² There was on it neither tree nor shrub except a small species of thorn and cactus, neither of which obtain a height of more than two or three feet. However, this has not always been the case; for there are existing evidences to indicate that the island was once covered with timber. Nidever mentions scrub trees and moss in 1850, but there was not enough to give any protection. Much of the surface is covered with dead land shells--helix, trionix, and helix gabbi.³ When

¹Ventura, Observer, December 20, 1892.

²According to Nidever and Sparks there were no trees.

³Ventura, Observer, December 20, 1892.



they flourished, there must have been a great deal of vegetation on the island. Their large size and numbers are noticeable to even the casual observer.

These shells were used by the Indians as money. Shells from this island have been found in the region of the San Joaquin Valley where they were identified by the engraving on them as having originated on this one island, which has led to the belief that there was a trade carried on all over the central region of California by the Indians.⁴

Although the island was characterized as being wind-swept, this is true only at certain seasons of the year; at other times the sea and the climate are calm and serene. During the season in which the wind prevails, it is difficult to land and more difficult to remain at anchor. The writer spent a week on the island in the month of September. Several times during this week the sea lashed furiously, while the waves and spray were flung thirty feet high to dash against the rocky shore. The noise made by the tumultuous ocean closely resembled thunder, and the entire island seemed to shake when each wave broke upon the rocks. Even after living all my life on or near the ocean, never before had I witnessed such a natural phenomenon.

When Cabrillo sailed up the coast four hundred or

⁴There is a display of these shells, the engravings, and their approximate value at the Southwest Museum.

more years ago, he seems not to have discovered San Nicolas Island; nor was it seen by Vancouver during his voyage years later. The earliest recorded voyagers who visited the island named it "Sea Otter Island," because of the great number of sea otters found there. At the present time there are numerous aquatic birds, land birds, and a small fox on the island. Numerous skeletons of two species of dog are to be found on the island. These dogs were living as late as 1853; they had been domesticated by the Indians.⁵

The relics found on the island display a workmanship superior to that of relics found on the other islands and on the mainland. This indicates contact with the northern tribes. The barbed spear points used in fishing are not found on the other channel islands.⁶ The island aborigines fashioned many implements from stone and bone, but the use of these implements is a puzzle to archeologists. The opinion is held that there was on this island a comparatively higher civilization found than on the mainland and on the other islands. The inhabitants seemed to have been of superior physical mould; the women were tall, handsome, and of a lighter complexion than the other natives of this region.⁷

⁵John Price, Diary of Year 1860, 16.

⁶Ventura, Observer, December 20, 1892.

⁷Ibid.

Between 1803 and 1840 the Russians habitually visited San Nicolas Island in their search for the valuable fur of the sea otter. They brought with them natives of Alaska to whom they had taught the use of firearms. It is said that the Russians left some of these natives on the island to continue the work of capturing otters after the Russians' vessels had sailed north. While the Russians were absent, these Alaskan Indians took possession of the women on the island. In the conflict which followed all the men and male children were killed. When the Russian ships returned and removed the Alaskans, the women were abandoned to their fate. In some way this news reached the mission fathers; and the story which follows tells of the Indians' removal and the story of the lone woman of San Nicolas Island.

George Nidever's statement regarding the old Indian woman of San Nicolas Island, the manner in which she was left, and the circumstances of her rediscovery is, in substance as follows:⁸

In the month of August, 1835,⁹ to the best of Nidever's memory, Isaac J. Sparks, an otter hunter of Santa Barbara, Bill Williams¹⁰ of the Rancho Chino, and others to make twelve

⁸George Nidever, The Indian Woman of San Nicolas (MS).

⁹The exact date as taken from John Price's Diary of 1835 was August 21.

¹⁰"Bill Williams" should not be here confused with the "Bill Williams" of Rocky Mountain fame; it was Isaac Williams a member of the first Ewing Young expedition. The rest of the crew was Charles Hubbard and nine Kanakas, members of Sparks' otter hunting group.

all together, went over to San Nicolas Island in a schooner called the "Peores Nada" to remove the indians who then inhabited the island.¹¹ Sparks' group assembled the indians and brought them all, about 17 or 18 men, women, and children down to the beach. At this point one of the women asked permission to return to the interior of the island for her child, which, she said, had been left behind. She was allowed to leave, but during her absence a heavy wind sprang up which compelled the assembled indians and their guardians to leave the island and run before the wind, for the San Nicolas Island is on the outer rim of the channel and it affords no shelter whatever for vessels in a storm.

The "Peores Nada" arrived safely at San Pedro where she landed the Indians who went up to the San Gabriel Mission. It was the intention of Sparks' group to return to San Nicolas Island for the lone Indian woman, but the owner of the "Peores Nada" ordered the ship to Monterey where she was loaded with lumber for San Francisco. At the entrance to the Golden Gate she ran into a storm and capsized. As there was no other large craft on the coast, no attempt was made to rescue or to learn the fate of the Indian woman.¹²

¹¹"Peores Nada" was a ship of 20 tons, constructed in Monterey by Joaquin Gomez. With Captain Hubbard, the chief pilot, it was chartered by Isaac Sparks. She capsized at the entrance of San Francisco Harbor.

¹²The small boats used in otter hunting would not reach the island because it was at the closest point 50 miles from the mainland and 155 miles from the Santa Barbara Harbor.

About a month after the removal of the Indians, Nidever joined Isaac Sparks in an otter hunting trip to the islands of Santa Rosa and San Miguel. It was during this trip that Nidever learned from Sparks the facts of the Indians' removal from San Nicolas Island; but he did not learn the reason for their removal, by whose authority they were removed, or he could not recall these facts.¹³ He recollects quite clearly, however, that Bill Williams was with them and was evidently interested in the Indians' removal as Williams afterwards took one of the Indians to live with him.¹⁴

It was 1852 before any effort was made to learn the fate of the Indian woman who had been left on the island, although it was well known throughout the coast that she had been abandoned on the island. In the fall of 1851, Nidever went to San Nicolas in search of sea gull eggs; there he found footprints, which from their size, he concluded were those of a woman. Their appearance indicated that they had been made but a short time before, which led him to believe that the

¹³ Isaac J. Sparks, Diary, Year of 1835, 14. Sparks states that the removal was ordered by the mission fathers at San Gabriel. Also, the reason given for this was the depredations of the Northwest Indians in this area. George Nidever, Reminiscences of Scenes of Early Santa Barbara. In this manuscript Nidever states that he wanted to establish a sheep ranch on the island.

¹⁴ Nidever, ibid., 1. Sparks and Nidever had a brush with the Indians on this occasion. Sparks killed three of them.

Indian woman still existed.¹⁵ When he returned to Santa Barbara, he reported his discovery of the footprints to the mission fathers, who urged him to make a thorough search on his next visit to the island. However, he did not return to the island until the fall of 1858 when he went to the island on an otter hunting expedition. On his trip he was accompanied by Charley Brown and Sparks. The first day they went on shore they found a large woven basket made of grass in a crotch or fork of a large bush; in the basket were several shag skins cut into regular shapes, a dress made from the skins of the same bird, a sinew rope, a bone knife, abalone fish hooks, and several of these with a seal skin. Sparks and Nidever scattered the things about on the ground and left the basket lying there so that they might have some proof of the Indian woman's existence if, on their next visit, they found the things replaced in the basket or removed. During the next few days they were busy with their hunting, for they intended to resume the search as soon as their hunting would permit. On the third or fourth day a heavy gale sprang up which prevented their coming ashore and finally forced them to leave the island.

On the next trip to the island in the summer of 1853

¹⁵All thought she had perished.

Nidever and Charley Brown went without Sparks to the island, again in search of otter. When they went ashore to find where the otter lay, Brown discovered footprints on the northwest side of the island. They then decided to make a thorough search of the island on the next day.¹⁶

Accordingly, on the following morning, they took their men ashore. First they searched over a low, sandy flat, which was covered with dunes and bushes and which stretched across the island about a mile and a half below its head. Nidever took no active part in the search, but Brown went across with the men. When they found nothing, he sent them back with instructions to search carefully along the edges of the flat.¹⁷ He remained on that side of the island and proceeded towards its head until he struck the footprints which had been discovered the previous evening. When he followed them over the banks, he traced the tracks until they were lost on the soft carpet of moss with which the ground was covered.

Between the sand flat already mentioned and the head of the island there is a long, high ridge; it was up the northwest side of this ridge that Brown had followed the footprints. From this point he saw, further up the ridge, three huts. Upon reaching them, he found they were constructed of whale

¹⁶Nidever, op. cit., 2.

¹⁷Ventura, Observer, December 20, 1892.

bones which had been covered with brush.¹⁸ They were open all around and within the grass was growing thickly, which indicated that they had not been occupied for some time.

When he looked about over the ridge from this point, he discovered a small, black object which appeared to be moving and which looked very much like a crow seated on a bush. As he went towards it, he soon discovered it to be the Indian woman. She was seated crosslegged on the ground within a small, low, circular enclosure of sage brush, a type of wind break; she was engaged in separating the blubber from a piece of seal skin, which she held across her knee with one hand. In the other hand she held a rude knife, the blade of which was a piece of iron hove and the handle a piece of wood. Within the enclosure or wind break, a fire was smouldering, and without was a large pile of bones and ashes; evidently this enclosure had been her abode for a long time.¹⁹

Blankets woven of grass, water bottles of the same material made in the shape of a flagon and lined with asphaltum, knives of bone, and other articles lay scattered about. There were no stone mortars or earthen vessels, but there were several shovel or scoop-shaped vessels of wood, the use of which

¹⁸Mr. Aruther Woodward, of the Los Angeles Museum in Exposition Park, while on an archeological expedition to San Nicolas Island, reconstructed one of these huts; it can be seen in the museum.

¹⁹Nidever, op. cit., 4.

Brown did not learn.²⁰ Stretched between two upright stakes at some distance from the ground was a sinew rope from which were hanging strips of seal blubber.

The windbreak was situated on the northeast side of the island about half way up the ridge, so that it received the full force of the morning sun. The Indian woman was dressed in a robe or gown of bird skins sewn together with the feathers out and pointing downwards.²¹ This was her only covering. Her feet were bare as was her head, which was covered with a thick growth of matted hair. This was bleached to a reddish color and hung down to her shoulders.²² Her features were quite regular, complexion fairer than the Indians of the mainland and, although she must have been about fifty years old, her face was free of wrinkles. Her teeth were worn down to the very gums much like an Eskimo of the same age from eating dried seal meat. When Brown approached her it was from the rear so that she did not see him, although the wild dogs nearby began to growl when they saw him. These she yelled at and they went away. From the elevation where he stood he signalled

²⁰These had been left by the Indians when they were removed. She moved from the huts because the dogs on the island killed her child and attacked her. It was learned later that she used fire to protect herself. All of the above-described things were collected by the priest at the Santa Barbara Mission and sent to Rome. According to the soldiers who visited the Vatican, they are still on display there in the museum.

²¹The feathers were from the Shag which is dull black in colour.

²²Widever, op. cit., 4.

to the men who could be seen on the sand flat below, and they came towards the enclosure in a circle so she could not escape. As soon as they were near enough, Brown stepped around in front of her and was surprised by her smile and bow to him instead of becoming alarmed or startled.²³ As the other men came up she smiled to them, talking rapidly all the time but no one could understand her. Nidever then came up and they sat in a circle around her while she roasted some roots and invited them to share with her. Nidever feared that force would be necessary to take her with them, but Brown differed with him. After going through the motions of putting all the things in her baskets and walking off with them towards the beach and saying in Spanish "let us go" they had the satisfaction of seeing her face brighten up and she began to put all her things in the basket. When she had finished doing this she went with them down to the beach. They found a spring near the beach and left some of the things she had brought here. Farther on they came to a second spring where she stopped and worked. They had no difficulty at all in taking her on board the ship. They gave her some food on board the ship and she accepted it readily. That afternoon Brown made her a dress and a skirt of canvas to which was added a man's shirt, black necktie and an old cloak. These

²³ Charles Brown, Early History of Santa Barbara, 3.

she continued to wear while on the island. The following day they went ashore and camped, remaining here for almost a month. Near the camp they constructed a small hut to shelter her and here she remained most of the day, while all the men except the cook were off hunting otter. She was free to come and go but took only infrequent walks about the island and never made any move towards deserting her rescuers. She spent most of her time in weaving baskets, and brought wood and water for the cook. She showed at one time she desired to return to her former food. A sea otter was killed by the hunters and dragged up near the camp to be skinned. After this operation had been performed the carcass was being dragged to the water so that it would not contaminate the camp. At the sight of this she gave the hunters to understand this was a waste of meat. She then rushed down and seized it by the flipper and hauled it back. After it began to smell she showed her disgust for it, and her preference for the other food, and did not object to its being taken away.

On their way to the mainland she knelt in the bottom of the boat and made odd signs when the weather became rough and a storm was encountered. As they reached shore, an oxcart and a man on horseback came in sight and her delight was unbounded. She was taken to Nidever's home where she remained until her death about seven weeks later. She was allowed to eat too much fruit and vegetables which brought on dysentery. The mission fathers sent for Indians from San Gabriel, San

Fernando and Santa Ynez, besides those of the Santa Barbara Mission and San Buenaventura, in hope of finding someone to converse with her, but did not succeed. She would dance, smile and jabber for all, and when Sparks visited she would carry on a little chat and rock her arms as if her baby should be in them. Her dresses, baskets and other materials were collected by Father Gonzalez by whom they were sent to Rome. She is buried in the mission garden in Santa Barbara and the gravestone is entitled "Juana Maria."